

Short Game Best Drills and Tests

Understanding Proper Training

Most golfers practice the wrong way.

Most golfers practice a lot, but they don't see results or improvement. The time they put in doesn't correlate with the results they're getting.

To improve your short game, you must understand the difference between proper training and just hitting balls.

Block Practice vs Random Practice

Block Practice

Repeating the same shot over and over from the same location.

Example: 20 chips from the same spot using the same club.

Block practice is useful when learning a skill.

Random Practice

Changing clubs, targets, lies, and situations.

Example: Different chip shots around the green with different clubs.

Random practice is essential because it simulates the golf course.

Great practice sessions include both block and random practice.

Drills vs Tests

Drills

Used to build a skill.

- Repetition based
- Focused on technique and improvement

Tests

Used to measure skill.

- Pressure based
- One ball
- High expectation / High accountability

Drill first. Then test the skill.

Results vs Time

Bad practice goal: "I practiced for an hour."

Good practice goal: "I made 10 of 10 putts from four feet.
It took me two attempts and about 15 minutes."

Practice should be measured by results, not time.

Train Hard, Play Easy

Practice should be more demanding than the golf course.
If you can pass tests in training, the golf course feels easier.

Train hard. Play easy.

The Five Areas of the Short Game

To lower your scores, you must train these five areas:

1. Short Putting
2. Long Putting
3. Fringe Chipping
4. Pitching
5. Bunker Play

Each area includes:

- A drill to build skill
- A test to measure performance that transfers to the golf course

What You'll Need

For every practice session bring:

- Personal practice card
 - Pencil
 - Three golf balls
 - Five tees
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Short Putting

Most missed short putts are caused by poor face control.

Focus

Face control

Best Drill

Putting Sword or Gate Drill

Place the putting sword or gate around the putter head and roll putts through the gate to ensure the face is square at impact.

Short Putting Test

10 in a Row from Four Feet

Use a slight slope (about one degree).

Choose five positions around the hole.

Goal: Make 10 consecutive putts from four feet.

If you miss, continue until you reach 10, then restart.

Record how many attempts it takes to complete the test.

Long Putting

Most three-putts happen because of poor pace control, not line or read.

Focus

Speed control

Best Drills

Eyes on the Hole

Putting while looking at the hole improves feel and distance control.

One-Handed Putting

Promotes better contact and rhythm.

Long Putting Test

50 Point Game

Putt from 20–70 feet.

Scoring:

- Inside 3-foot circle = 1 point
- Make the putt = 2 points

Goal: 50 points every practice session.

Chipping

Great chippers control landing spot and rollout.

Focus

Landing zone control, Select a landing zone two paces onto the green.

Best Drill

Landing Zone Drill

Pick a landing spot two paces onto the green.

Use different clubs.

Goal: Land the ball within one foot of the landing spot three times in a row with each club.
Mark each landing spot with a tee.

Best Test

10 Hole Up-and-Down Test

Play 10 different chip shots.

Scoring:

- Up and down = 2 (par)
- Two shots = 3 (bogey)

Goal: 24 or better (a score that typically breaks 80).

Pitching

Better players know their exact wedge distances.

Focus

Wedge gapping

Know the distances for:

- Pitch shot
- Half swing
- Three-quarter swing
- Full swing

For each of your wedges.

Best Drill

Wedge Gapping Practice

Map the distance for each wedge and swing length.

Example: Wedge Matrix

Best Test

9-Hole Wedge Course - shots from 30–80 yards from the hole.

Play 9 holes using only wedge shots.

Scoring:

- 2 = Par
- 3 = Bogey
- 4 = Double

Track your score.

Bunker Play

Great bunker players control their entry point in the sand.

Focus

Consistent sand strike.



Best Drill

Line Drill

Draw a line in the sand.

Goal: Enter the sand at the start of the line three times in a row while accelerating through the sand.
The sand should splash onto the green.
The ball comes out with the sand.

Best Test

Hit 10 bunker shots.

Scoring:

- Miss green = 0 points
- Hit green = 1 point
- Inside 10 feet = 2 points
- Inside 6 feet = 3 points

Goal: 12 points or better.

Example Practice Session

Short Putting

Beat your personal best. Goal: 10 in a row

Long Putting

Goal: 50 points

Chipping

Goal: 24 or lower

Pitching

Gap two wedges with 10 balls each

Bunker Play

Goal: 12 points

Practice Structure

Every practice session should follow this structure:

Drill → Test → Track Results